MA ENGLISH • SEMESTER 1

Block 3 — Unit 1: Of Friendship and Of Truth - Francis Bacon

CHAUCER TO THE ELIZABETHAN AGE

Expanded exam notes · Simple explanations + developed discussion

Based on the supplied SGOU self-learning material (M21EG01DC). These are study aids, not the original textbook. Everyday comparisons are teaching examples. The original notes and full textbook units remain available in the subject folder.

The chapter in one sentence

Bacon explains why friendship helps people live and think better, and why truth matters even when falsehood is attractive.

Start with a picture

Imagine carrying a heavy schoolbag. A friend cannot erase every difficulty, but can help carry it, suggest a better route, or collect something you forgot. Bacon gives friendship emotional, intellectual, and practical value.

1. Of Friendship

First fruit: relief for the heart

Speaking honestly to a trusted friend gives feelings an outlet. Shared happiness becomes more enjoyable; shared sorrow becomes easier to bear. Being surrounded by people is not the same as having someone you trust.

Everyday example: you feel anxious before a presentation. Telling a trusted friend helps you feel less alone. The example illustrates Bacon’s point; it is not an incident from the essay.

Second fruit: clearer judgement

A friend can offer advice and help organise confused thoughts. We often excuse our own mistakes or see only one side. An honest outsider may notice what we miss.

Everyday example: you think a teacher dislikes you. A friend points out that the same correction was given to everyone. Your interpretation becomes less one-sided.

Bacon also suggests that explaining thoughts aloud can clarify them. Conversation is useful even before the friend offers a solution.

Third fruit: help in action

A friend can do things we cannot easily do for ourselves: speak on our behalf, assist with responsibilities, and continue important concerns. Friendship extends a person’s practical capacities.

Bacon gives examples involving powerful people as well as ordinary needs. His focus is on what friendship does for human life.

A thoughtful qualification

Bacon's approach can sound practical or **utilitarian** because he examines benefits. That does not mean friendship is merely buying services. Emotional trust and honest counsel remain central.

2. Of Truth

What problem does Bacon explore?

People may say they value truth while enjoying lies, flattering stories, and comforting illusions. Truth can be less colourful than invention and less convenient than deception.

Imagine someone exaggerating a small achievement because the grander story sounds more exciting. Bacon asks why people enjoy the attractive false version.

Distinguish kinds of falsehood

Imaginative fiction is not automatically the same as dishonest deception. A made-up story offered as a story is different from a false statement used to mislead someone. Bacon's essay considers the attraction and moral consequences of falsehood.

Why does truth matter?

Truth provides a reliable basis for understanding and conduct. In social dealings, honesty supports trust. A dishonest person may gain a short advantage but damage the relationships on which shared life depends.

Images make the argument memorable

Bacon contrasts clear light with the artificial attractiveness that disguise can create. He also imagines the pleasure of reaching a position from which confusion can be understood. Such images turn an abstract moral argument into something readers can picture.

Notice Bacon's style

- **Aphorism:** a compact, memorable statement.
- **Analogy:** an explanation through comparison.
- **Allusion:** a reference to a familiar story, writer, or tradition.
- **Compression:** much meaning placed in few words.

Do not turn an aphorism into an isolated slogan. Explain the argument around it.

Build an exam answer

For friendship: introduce Bacon's practical view, explain the three fruits, give examples, and conclude with the relation between feeling, judgement, and action.

For truth: explain the attraction of falsehood, the value of truth, and the connection between honesty and social trust. Add one image or stylistic feature.

Quick check

1. What are friendship’s three main benefits? **Emotional relief, clearer understanding, and practical help.**
2. Is a crowd enough to remove loneliness? **No; trust matters more than numbers.**
3. Is every invented story a dishonest lie? **No; context and the intention to deceive matter.**

Develop an exam answer

Practice question

Explain Bacon’s practical understanding of friendship and truth.

Expanded discussion

Bacon’s account of friendship begins with the recognition that people need more than physical company. A crowded setting may still leave someone inwardly isolated. The first benefit of a trusted friendship is the ability to communicate feeling, reducing the burden of grief and increasing the enjoyment of happiness. The essay thus presents emotional openness as a practical necessity rather than a weakness.

Friendship also improves judgement. People are vulnerable to self-flattery, confusion, and partial views of their own circumstances. A friend’s counsel can introduce another perspective, while the act of explaining a difficulty can itself make thought clearer. The third benefit extends into action: a friend may speak, assist, or carry forward concerns in ways a person cannot easily manage alone. Taken together, the three fruits connect the heart, the understanding, and the conduct of life.

Of Truth examines a different but related problem: people often desire the pleasure or convenience of falsehood even while publicly praising truth. Bacon’s reflections suggest that dishonesty damages the trust necessary for social dealings. The attraction of an embellished story or flattering belief must therefore be distinguished from its reliability. His imagery makes this moral problem concrete by contrasting clarity with the appearances produced by artificial light or disguise.

The essays share an interest in the conditions of sound judgement. Honest counsel and commitment to truth both challenge the comforting distortions people create for themselves. Bacon’s aphoristic style reinforces the practical emphasis by giving arguments a memorable shape. However, a good answer should unpack those compact statements, showing their reasoning rather than merely repeating them.

Suggested answer structure

1. Introduce Bacon’s concern with conduct
2. Explain three fruits of friendship
3. Discuss why falsehood attracts
4. Explain truth and trust
5. Connect ideas with aphoristic style

Common mistakes to avoid

Do not describe friendship only as emotional comfort; include understanding and action. Do not equate openly declared imaginative fiction with deliberate deception.

Turn this into your own answer

Read the question again and choose only relevant sections. Make one clear point per paragraph, explain it, and connect it with a specific textual detail. Add accurate short quotations from the textbook where useful; the discussion above is paraphrase, not quoted text. Adjust length to the marks and time available.

Coverage review: extra exam details

Bacon’s historical examples and verbal images

Of Friendship uses relationships involving Sulla and Pompey, Julius Caesar and Decimus Brutus, Augustus and Agrippa, Tiberius and Sejanus, and Septimius Severus and Plautianus. Their purpose is to show that rank and political power do not remove the need for a confidant. Such relationships also expose risks when intimacy, dependence, and power mix. The Brutus relevant to Bacon’s account of Caesar’s special favour is Decimus, not an unqualified substitution of Marcus Brutus.

The image of consuming one’s own heart gives emotional isolation a physical force. The comparison with unfolding a rich tapestry helps explain how thoughts become clearer when expressed. These examples are useful evidence for a discussion of analogy and compressed argument.

Of Truth opens with Pilate’s question and his failure to wait for an answer. Revise the images of daylight and candlelight, pearl and precious stones, and the mixture of an inferior metal with gold. They explore the attraction of embellished appearance and the damage done when falsehood enters conduct. The pursuit, knowledge, and belief of truth are central distinctions in Bacon’s religious and ethical account.

Aphoristic versus personal essay

An aphoristic essay concentrates general observations in memorable propositions. A personal essay more visibly follows an individual’s experiences or shifting reflections. These tendencies can overlap, but Bacon’s method here is chiefly compressed and argumentative rather than autobiographical storytelling.

Textbook assignment checklist

These are the unit’s assignment prompts, included as a revision checklist, not as predictions of the exam. Longer answers still need evidence from the assigned texts.

1. Explain the theme of “Of Friendship.”
2. Elaborate instances taken from history to prove the importance given to friendship by kings and emperors.
3. Elaborate on the contribution of Bacon as an essayist.
4. Differentiate between personal and aphoristic essays.

5. Write on the themes of the essay “Of Truth”
6. Why do men love a lie more than the truth?
7. What type of essay is “Of Truth”?
8. What is the truth according to Bacon?
9. What are the qualities of Bacon’s essays?
10. Make a list of some oft-quoted statements from Bacon’s essays.